FO GUANG SHAN / HSI LAI TEMPLE SCRIPT

Beginner Glossary for the Samādhi Water Repentance

A plain-language companion to the English translation in Scrolls One, Two, and Three

389	3	175
glossary entries	complete scrolls	source PDF pages

Designed for clear on-screen reading and practical A4 printing.
Lineage terminology checked against Fo Guang Shan reference sources.

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EXPANDED COMPANION EDITION

Water Repentance Glossary

Plain-English meanings, difficult phrases and useful distinctions

Prepared by **Daniel Franjkovic**

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Source edition

Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple, Electronic Edition 3.0, April 2022.
English translation, editing and design by Andrew Nguy and Raymond Kong.

This independent companion explains the source liturgy. It is not a replacement translation or an official temple edition. Source-page references count PDF pages; printed page numbers are given where useful. In communal practice, follow the officiant's instructions.

The original liturgies remain copyrighted by Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple and are linked in the references. New explanations and reading notes are clearly distinguished from source wording.

Further Buddhist terminology: www.fgsitc.org/glossary/

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Contents

Page numbers and PDF bookmarks lead to the main sections and reading aids.

Glossary 4

How to use this glossary 4

The six senses at a glance 4

Consolidated glossary 5

Passages and terms that remain unclear 23

Sources used for the terminology pass 24

Pronunciation 25

Quick Sanskrit key 25

Names used often 26

Important Buddhist terms 27

Chanting the non-English lines 27

A small Vietnamese name bridge 29

References 30

Source liturgy 30

Fo Guang Shan and Hsi Lai Temple resources 30

Terminology and language sources 30

Canonical and translation sources 30

Later Pure Land teaching used with a clear label 31

Historical and academic studies 31

Figure relationships and recognition 31

Artwork records 32

Editorial limits 32

Glossary

Terms from all three scrolls

This glossary is consolidated from the English translation in all three scrolls (175 PDF pages in total). Repeated terms are listed once. Sanskrit spellings generally follow the PDFs. Explanations describe how a term is used in this Chinese Mahāyāna Buddhist liturgy; they do not imply that every Buddhist tradition uses it in exactly the same way.

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For additional Buddhist terminology, visit the Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center glossary.

How to use this glossary

Look up a word, numbered teaching, ritual action, title, place, or unusual expression in the alphabetical table. Cross-references are included in the explanation itself. Where the English edition uses an unusual translation, the explanation gives the more familiar Buddhist term. A few compressed phrases cannot be identified with certainty; these are described carefully and collected after the table.

The English translation was used to select the original glossary entries. Chinese characters and transliteration were consulted to identify unclear labels and, in this edition, to explain the chant passages. Recognisable Sanskrit words are explained, but uncertain transmitted syllables are not forced into invented translations.

The six senses at a glance

In Buddhist analysis, the mind is the sixth sense. Each faculty meets a corresponding object, and the relevant consciousness arises. Together these form the basic structure of ordinary experience.

Sense faculty	Sense object	Consciousness	Everyday example
Eye	Forms, colours, and shapes	Visual consciousness	Seeing a flower
Ear	Sounds	Auditory consciousness	Hearing a bell
Nose	Odours	Olfactory consciousness	Smelling incense
Tongue	Tastes	Taste consciousness	Tasting tea
Body	Tangible objects: pressure, texture, temperature, and pain	Tactile consciousness	Feeling warmth
Mind	Mental objects: thoughts, memories, images, emotions, and ideas	Mental consciousness	Remembering a conversation

The relationship can be summarized as:

> sense faculty + sense object + corresponding consciousness → contact → feeling → possible craving, aversion, or confusion

The sequence is not a claim that every experience must end in craving or aversion. Practice develops mindfulness and wisdom so that contact and feeling can be known without automatically turning into grasping or rejection. “Mind” here means the faculty that knows mental events; it is not a permanent soul.

Consolidated glossary

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
“3x”	Repeat the preceding chant, name, or action three times.
Affinities; virtuous affinities	Relationships and circumstances created by past and present actions. “Creating affinities” means forming helpful connections with people and with Buddhist practice.
Affliction	A mental state such as greed, anger, jealousy, pride, or ignorance that disturbs the mind and leads to suffering or harmful action.
Afflictions of views and thoughts; “thoughts after seeing the truth”	A distinction between mistaken beliefs cut through by insight and subtler emotional habits removed through continued cultivation. The PDF’s phrase “thoughts after seeing the truth” is awkward in English.
Ahaha, Ababa, Atata, and Alala Hells	Names representing cries or sounds made by beings suffering in extreme cold. They belong to the traditional cold-hell imagery, not to an ordinary spoken vocabulary.
Aloeswood; turuṣka incense	Aromatic materials burned as valuable ritual offerings. Turuṣka is an old name generally associated with frankincense or a similar imported resin.
Amitābha Buddha; Amitāyus; Infinite Life Tathāgata; Guide and Receiver of the West	Amitābha means “Infinite Light” and Amitāyus means “Infinite Life”. They are closely related names for the same Buddha in this text, although some rituals and artworks emphasise one aspect. “Guide and Receiver” describes Amitābha welcoming beings who aspire to rebirth in the Western Pure Land.
Ānāpānasmṛti	Mindfulness of breathing: calmly attending to inhalation and exhalation as a meditation practice.
Ancestral Master	A respected teacher in the historical lineage through which a Buddhist tradition or practice was transmitted.
Anuttarāsamyaksaṃbodhi	“Unsurpassed, complete awakening”: the full enlightenment attained by a Buddha.
Arhat	A person who has awakened through the Buddha’s teaching and is liberated from the cycle of rebirth. In Mahāyāna texts, this attainment is respected but distinguished from the bodhisattva path to full Buddhahood.
Asaṃkhyeya; asaṃkhyeya kalpa	Asaṃkhyeya means “incalculable.” An asaṃkhyeya kalpa is an unimaginably long span of time.
Asura	A powerful, competitive, and often jealous being in Buddhist cosmology, sometimes translated as a demigod or titan.
Attachment to precepts, rites, and rituals	Mistaking rules or ceremonies for ends in themselves, or believing that outward observance alone guarantees liberation. It does not mean that all precepts or rituals are rejected.
Avalokiteśvara Bodhisattva; Guanyin; Great Compassion; Compassionate Lord; Great Compassionate One	The bodhisattva who embodies compassion and responds to the suffering of beings. Guanyin is the familiar Chinese name. In the memorial rite, Avalokiteśvara is also the speaker of the *Heart Sūtra* teaching on the emptiness of the five aggregates.
Avīci Hell; Uninterrupted Hell	The most severe hell realm in the cosmology used by the text, where suffering is described as continuous.
Beginningless time	A conventional way of saying that no first beginning of the cycle of ignorance, karma, and rebirth can be identified.
Benefactor families	Lay donors and their households who support the temple or service and for whom blessings are dedicated.
Bhagavān; Great Awakened One; Honored One; World-Honored One	Reverential titles for a Buddha. Bhagavān is often rendered “Blessed One”; “Awakened One” explains the basic meaning of “Buddha.”
Bhaiṣajyaguru; Medicine Master Buddha; Medicine Buddha	The Buddha whose name means “Medicine Teacher”. His twelve vows address sickness, material need, ethical confusion and supportive conditions for awakening. A medicine bowl or medicinal fruit may identify him in art, but forms vary by region.
Bhikṣu	A fully ordained Buddhist monk.
Bhikṣuṇī	A fully ordained Buddhist nun.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Blue-robed child	A youthful ritual or iconographic attendant who presents flowers to the Compassionate Lord. The English text does not identify the figure more precisely.
Bodh Gaya	The place in present-day India where Śākyamuni Buddha attained awakening beneath the bodhi tree.
Bodhi mind; bodhi resolve; Mahāyāna aspiration	The intention to attain full Buddhahood in order to help all beings become free from suffering. Also called bodhicitta.
Bodhi; awakening	Awakening to reality and freedom from ignorance. “Bodhi” is the Sanskrit word commonly translated as enlightenment or awakening.
Bodhisattva	One committed to the path of full Buddhahood for the benefit of all beings. The word can refer to great celestial figures or to human practitioners following this vow.
Bodhisattva precepts	Mahāyāna ethical commitments centred on avoiding harm, cultivating goodness, and acting for the liberation of all beings. Different lineages transmit somewhat different formal lists.
Bodhisattva stages; Ten Grounds; First through Tenth Stages	Progressive levels of realisation and compassionate ability on the bodhisattva path. The Ten Grounds are advanced stages leading towards Buddhahood.
Bodhisattva-Mahāsattva	“Bodhisattva, great being”: an emphatic honorific for a highly advanced bodhisattva.
Brahmā; King Brahmā	A high celestial being associated with the form realm. He is powerful and long-lived but is not a creator god in the Buddhist framework of this text.
Buddha	An “awakened one” who has fully overcome ignorance and perfected wisdom and compassion. Śākyamuni is the Buddha of our historical world; the text also invokes many other Buddhas.
Buddha light; clouds of kindness	Devotional metaphors for the wisdom, protection, and compassion of a Buddha reaching and supporting beings.
Buddha nature; awakened nature; proper cause of awakening	The capacity or basis within sentient beings for awakening. It should not be read here as an ordinary permanent ego or soul.
Buddha-land	A realm associated with a Buddha and shaped by that Buddha’s vows and teaching activity. A purified Buddha-land is called a Pure Land.
Buddhadharma; Buddha Dharma	The Buddha’s teaching and the path of practice based on it.
Buddha’s work	Activity that teaches, protects, or otherwise helps beings move towards awakening.
Budai	A tenth-century Chinese monk remembered with a cloth sack, laughing face and round belly, and later revered as a manifestation of Maitreya. Budai and the princely bodhisattva Maitreya are two different visual forms connected by this East Asian tradition.
Buddhist names in the repeated litany: Nāgagotrodārajñānarāja, Nāgeśvararāja, Buddhapuṇḍarīkadhyaneśvararāja, Kasayadhvaja, and Siṃhanāda	Buddhas invoked by name in the ritual. The English text does not tell their stories; for a beginner, the important point is that each is honoured as a fully awakened Buddha. “Siṃhanāda” means “lion’s roar,” a common image for fearless teaching.
“Calculating every hour and selling the days”	Archaic wording for making profit through accumulating interest over time, especially exploitative moneylending.
Canonical account; traditional account; recognition cue	Labels used in the figure profiles. A canonical account appears in a cited Buddhist scripture. A traditional account belongs to a recognised religious narrative without being presented as modern historical biography. A recognition cue is an attribute often used in art, not a guarantee that every unlabelled image has been identified correctly.
Causes and conditions	The many factors on which an event or experience depends. Buddhism uses this phrase to reject the idea that things arise independently or without causes.
Celestial; heavenly being; deva	A being reborn in a heavenly realm because of wholesome karma. Devas enjoy great pleasure and long life but are still impermanent and within saṃsāra.
Chan	The Chinese Buddhist meditation tradition known as Zen in Japanese.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Circumambulation	Walking respectfully around a sacred image, altar, stūpa, or hall, usually keeping it to one's right.
Compiled Method; repentance method; Dharma method	An organized practice or ritual procedure. "Method" here does not mean a scientific method.
Conditioned existence; conditioned phenomena	Things that arise because of causes and conditions and therefore change and cease.
Confession	Openly acknowledging harmful actions instead of hiding them. In this liturgy it is paired with repentance and a resolve to change.
Contemplation of impurities	Meditation on the body's physical components and impermanence to reduce infatuation and attachment, not to encourage hatred of the body.
Dānapāramitā	The perfection of generosity: developing giving so fully that it supports the bodhisattva path to awakening.
Dedicating merit to the Three Realms	Using wholesome action mainly to seek better rebirth or pleasure within saṃsāra, rather than directing it towards liberation and the benefit of all beings. The text treats this as an incomplete use of merit.
Dedication of merits; dedication verse; dedicative report	Directing the hoped-for benefit of a practice towards other beings and towards awakening, rather than keeping the benefit for oneself alone.
Devas and nāgas; Eightfold Division of Devas and Nāgas	Traditional classes of nonhuman beings who attend and protect the Dharma. The full group commonly includes devas, nāgas, yakṣas, asuras, gandharvas, garuḍas, kiṃnaras, and mahoragas.
Deviant views; wrong views; other paths	Tradition-internal labels for beliefs considered to obstruct liberation, especially denial of ethical cause and effect or attachment to a permanent self. They can sound dismissive when applied to other religions or philosophies.
Dhāraṇī	A sacred recitation intended to retain a teaching, focus the mind, or invoke protection and blessing. Its Sanskrit sounds are often preserved rather than translated word for word.
Dharma	Depending on context: the Buddha's teaching, the truth taught by the Buddha, a particular teaching or practice, or - when written as "dharmas" - phenomena or elements of experience.
Dharma body; non-dual Dharma body	The Buddha understood as ultimate truth or reality itself, not merely as a historical physical body.
Dharmākara Bodhisattva	Amitābha Buddha during the bodhisattva career described in Pure Land scriptures. Dharmākara's forty-eight vows establish the conditions of Sukhāvatī. The name therefore belongs to the vow-making story, while Amitābha names the Buddha after their fulfilment.
Dharma door; Dharma gate	A teaching or practice that provides an entry into understanding and liberation. "Eighty-four thousand Dharma gates" means an immense variety suited to different beings.
Dharma protector	A deity, spirit, or practitioner understood to guard Buddhist teachings, places, and communities.
Dharma realm; Dharma realms	The total field of reality and all beings and phenomena within it. In ritual language, "all Dharma realms" can simply mean everywhere and everything.
Dharma Talk by Officiant	Teaching or closing guidance given by the ritual leader after the liturgy.
Dharma throne; lion throne; jeweled or lotus throne	An elevated ceremonial seat for a Buddha image or teacher. "Lion" suggests fearless authority in teaching, not a throne made for a literal lion.
Dhyāna; meditative concentration	Deep, stable meditation. The Four Dhyānas are progressively quieter states associated with the form realm.
Dīpaṃkara Buddha	A Buddha of the distant past whose name means "Maker of Light". A traditional account says he predicted the future Buddhahood of Śākyamuni after the bodhisattva spread his hair over muddy ground. Scroll Three invokes Dīpaṃkara in its lamp praise.
Dispassion	Freedom from compulsive craving and clinging. It means clear nonattachment, not coldness or lack of care.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Eight Cold and Eight Hot Hells; named hells such as Black String, Mountains of Knives, Trees of Swords, Boiling Cauldron, and Iron Bed	Traditional hell realms whose names describe particular forms of intense suffering. The liturgy uses vivid images to stress the gravity of harmful action. Buddhist readers differ over how literally or symbolically to understand them.
Eight Defilements	Mental stains that cloud clear awareness and condition harmful reactions. The source uses the numbered label but does not enumerate which eight are intended, so this guide does not impose a fixed list.
Eight Delusions; Eight Inversions	Eight ways of seeing qualities backwards. Four take what is impermanent, unsatisfactory, without a fixed self, and impure to be permanent, blissful, a self, and pure. In a Mahāyāna *Nirvāṇa Sūtra* framework, four more deny the ultimate permanence, bliss, true self, and purity attributed to a Buddha's nirvāṇa.
Eight Difficulties	Eight situations considered especially obstructive to hearing and practicing the Dharma, such as rebirth in painful realms or at a time and place where the teaching is unavailable.
Eight kinds of voices; Four kinds of eloquence	Ideal qualities of awakened speech: a voice that is clear and fitting for listeners, together with unobstructed command of meaning, teaching, expression, and explanation.
Eight Liberations	Eight advanced meditative releases, moving from disciplined contemplation of form through the formless concentrations to complete cessation.
Eight Masteries of the Self	A Mahāyāna expression for the Buddha's complete freedom and ability to manifest and act without the limitations of ordinary clinging. It is not the ordinary ego gaining total control.
Eight Precepts	A one-day or short-term lay discipline: refraining from killing, stealing, sexual activity, false speech, intoxicants, eating after noon, entertainment or adornment, and luxurious beds or seats.
Eight Seasonal Markers	Traditional observance dates tied to the changing seasons. The English text does not state exactly which calendar scheme is intended.
Eight Sufferings	Birth, ageing, illness, death, separation from what one loves, meeting what one dislikes, not getting what one wants, and suffering connected with the five aggregates.
Eight Worldly Winds	Gain and loss, praise and blame, fame and disgrace, pleasure and pain - the changing conditions that can push an unsteady mind around.
Eighteen Distinct Traits	Eighteen qualities traditionally said to distinguish a Buddha's perfect conduct, mindfulness, concentration, wisdom, and liberating activity.
Eighteen Realms	The six sense organs, their six objects, and the six corresponding consciousnesses. Together they describe the structure of ordinary experience.
Eighty-Four Thousand Gates of Affliction	A conventional enormous number representing the full variety of mental defilements. It corresponds to the image of equally numerous Dharma gates that can remedy them.
Eleven Biases; Eleven Pervasive Afflictions	The PDF's "Biases" translates a list of afflictions that spread through many other confused states. Seven concern misunderstanding the truth of suffering - five wrong views, doubt, and ignorance - and four concern its origin - wrong view, attachment to views, doubt, and ignorance.
Eleven Kinds of Emptiness	Eleven applications of insight into the lack of fixed, independent essence. Different scholastic presentations vary, and the PDF does not list the eleven.
Emptiness; empty nature	The teaching that things have no fixed, independent essence; they exist through causes, conditions, parts, and concepts. "Empty" does not mean that nothing exists or that actions have no consequences.
Enmity; karmic enmity; spiteful karma	A hostile relationship believed to have been created by past harm and carried forward through karmic causes. Repentance is presented as a way to end the cycle of retaliation.
Enter the Dharma flow	Become steadily aligned with the teaching and its movement towards awakening. "Flow" is a metaphor, not a physical stream.
Entering Repentance; Exiting Repentance	Formal prayers that open and close a scroll's repentance service.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Equanimity	A balanced, impartial care that does not collapse into favoritism, hatred, or emotional reactivity. It is one of the Four Limitless Minds.
Essence and spirit	Traditional language for a person's vital and conscious aspect. The wording should not automatically be taken as teaching an eternal soul, which Buddhism generally denies.
Eternal night	A metaphor for the long darkness of ignorance and repeated rebirth without awakening.
Eternalism and nihilism	Two rejected extremes: believing in an unchanging eternal self, or believing that persons and actions simply become nothing and therefore have no moral consequences.
Eternally abiding Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha	The Triple Gem understood as an enduring source of refuge beyond the lifespan of any one teacher or institution.
Expedient means; skilful means	A teaching or action adapted to a particular person's needs and capacity in order to guide that person towards liberation.
Field of merit	A person or community towards whom generosity is considered especially spiritually fruitful, just as good soil helps a seed produce a crop.
Five Aggregates	Form or body, sensation, perception, volition or mental formations, and consciousness. Buddhism analyzes a person as these changing processes rather than as a permanent self.
Five celestial attendants; Five Divine Messengers	Signs that awaken a person to life's vulnerability and moral urgency: a helpless infant, an aged person, a sick person, a person undergoing punishment for wrongdoing, and a dead person. "Messengers" is clearer than the PDF's "attendants"; they are reminders, not a household retinue.
Five Coverings	Sense desire, ill will, drowsiness, restlessness and worry, and doubt - mental hindrances that cover clarity and concentration.
Five Degenerations	Five worsening conditions said to mark a troubled age: decline in the age itself, views, afflictions, living beings, and lifespan. "Defiled home of the five degenerations" means this difficult world.
Five Desires	Craving for pleasing sights, sounds, smells, tastes, and touches. Some monastic lists use the phrase more broadly for desired material supports.
Five Eyes	Five increasingly profound ways of "seeing": ordinary physical sight, heavenly sight, wisdom insight, Dharma insight, and a Buddha's complete vision.
Five Faculties and Five Powers	Faith, effort, mindfulness, concentration, and wisdom. They are "faculties" while developing and "powers" when firmly established.
Five Forms of Stinginess	Clinging possessively to one's residence, supporters or family, material gains, praise, or knowledge of the Dharma.
Five Grave Deeds	The most serious traditional offenses: killing one's mother, killing one's father, killing an arhat, maliciously shedding a Buddha's blood, and causing a schism in the Sangha.
Five kinds of people	The Chinese phrase in the sexual-conduct passage most likely refers to an ancient Vinaya classification of five types of *paṇḍaka* or "non-male" person. Those categories were based on premodern ideas about anatomy, castration, sexual function, and bodily transformation; the English edition does not name them individually.
Five Minds	A technical analysis of stages in a moment of perception, commonly described as first impression, searching attention, decision, wholesome or unwholesome response, and continuation. The PDF does not define the term.
Five Parts of the Dharma Body	Five perfected qualities: ethical discipline, concentration, wisdom, liberation, and knowledge or vision of liberation. The PDF once prints "Dhama Body," apparently a typo for "Dharma Body."
Five Precepts	Basic lay ethical commitments: refrain from killing, stealing, sexual misconduct, false speech, and intoxicants.
Five pungent vegetables	Strong-smelling plants traditionally restricted in some East Asian Buddhist diets, commonly garlic, onions, leeks, chives, and asafoetida or a related allium.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Five Realms	Heavenly beings, humans, animals, hungry ghosts, and hell beings. A Six Realms scheme counts asuras separately instead of grouping them with another realm.
Five signs of decay	Signs that a deva's long heavenly life is ending, traditionally including fading adornments, wilting flowers, bodily changes, and loss of ease on the celestial seat.
Five Stages of Misconceptions	Five layers or "dwelling places" of delusion, from wrong views and desire-realm attachments through subtler attachments in higher realms to fundamental ignorance.
Five Types and Seven Categories of Vinaya Violations	Two technical ways of classifying monastic offenses by their kind and seriousness. The exact categories depend on the Vinaya system, and the PDF does not enumerate them.
Five Views	Belief in a permanent self, extreme views such as eternalism or annihilationism, denial of moral causation, treating one's own wrong view as supreme, and clinging to rites as sufficient for liberation.
Five Wisdoms	Five dimensions of awakened knowing: the wisdom of reality itself, mirror-like wisdom, equality, discerning wisdom, and all-accomplishing wisdom.
Five worldly teachings; five worldly dharmas	The PDF contrasts these with the Noble Eightfold Path. A traditional commentary identifies the five as conventional names, conventional sentences, the five aggregates, the eighteen realms of experience, and the twenty-five modes of conditioned existence. The point is that analyzing ordinary conventions is not the same as following the path to liberation.
Flowers of transgression; causing them to wilt	A ritual metaphor: harmful actions are imagined as flowers that wither when their causes are confessed and abandoned.
Flying zombies; hundred monsters; evil ghosts	Premodern terms for feared supernatural beings, omens, or calamity-bringing forces. The PDF offers no taxonomy, and a modern reader need not treat them as medical explanations.
Form is emptiness; emptiness is form	The Heart Sūtra's statement that physical and mental phenomena function conventionally but have no fixed, independent essence. Emptiness is not a separate substance behind form.
Four Attachments	Four rigid positions about phenomena: that all things are one, are different, are both one and different, or are neither. The point is that turning any of these conceptual positions into an absolute view becomes an obstruction.
Four Attachments or Stations of Consciousness	Four ways consciousness is described as settling on form, sensation, perception, and volitional formations.
Four Bindings; Four Shackles	Desire, anger, clinging to ineffective rites, and belief in a permanent self - forces said to tie beings to suffering.
Four Conditions	Four broad kinds of causal support: a direct cause, the immediately preceding condition, an object of attention, and other enabling conditions.
Four Desires; Four Cravings	Attachment to the four material requisites traditionally used by monastics: clothing, food, lodging, and medicine. The fault is compulsive attachment, not the practical use of necessities.
Four Dhyānas	Four progressively refined states of meditative absorption, moving from joyful collectedness to deep equanimity and stillness.
Four Elements	Earth or solidity, water or cohesion, fire or temperature, and wind or movement - the traditional analysis of physical matter and the body.
Four Elements as venomous snakes; Five Aggregates as bandits; Six Senses as an empty formation	Strong cautionary metaphors. They say that clinging to body and mind can betray or endanger us; they do not mean that the body, senses, or every experience is morally evil.
Four Emptinesses; four formless concentrations	Concentrations on infinite space, infinite consciousness, nothingness, and neither perception nor non-perception. "Emptinesses" here means formless meditative attainments, not four separate definitions of emptiness.
Four Faiths	Stable trust in the Buddha, Dharma, Sangha, and ethical conduct.
Four Forms of Birth; Four Forms of Existence	Traditional modes of rebirth: birth from a womb, from an egg, from moisture, or by spontaneous transformation.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Four Fruitions and Four Progressions	Four levels of early Buddhist awakening - stream-enterer, once-returner, non-returner, and arhat - each considered as the path towards it and the attainment of its result.
Four graspings	Clinging to sensual pleasure, views, rites and rules as ends in themselves, and a doctrine of a permanent self.
Four kindnesses	Great debts of gratitude, commonly understood in East Asian Buddhism as owed to parents, sentient beings, society or rulers, and the Triple Gem. Lists can vary.
Four Kinds of Fearlessness	A Buddha's confidence in teaching: complete awakening, ending the outflows, identifying obstacles, and showing the path that ends suffering.
Four Kinds of Observation	The four reflections stated in Scroll Two: examine causes and conditions, karmic results, one's own conditioned body, and the awakened qualities of a Buddha.
Four Kinds of Offering	The basic material supports offered to monastics: food, clothing, lodging or bedding, and medicine.
Four Lemmas	A four-way test of a claim: it is, is not, both is and is not, or neither is nor is not. It is used to expose the limits of rigid conceptual positions.
Four Limitless or Immeasurable Minds	Loving-kindness, compassion, appreciative joy, and equanimity extended without limit to all beings.
Four Lower Realms	Hells, hungry ghosts, animals, and asuras. Some passages instead say "Three Lower Realms," omitting asuras as a separate lower category.
Four Major and Eight Major Offenses	Serious violations in particular monastic and lay-bodhisattva precept systems. The exact list depends on which precept code is meant, and the PDF does not identify the code.
Four Means of Embracing	Four ways a bodhisattva draws people towards well-being and the Dharma: generosity, kind speech, helpful action, and cooperation or empathy.
Four Noble Truths	The truth of suffering or dissatisfaction, its origin in craving and ignorance, its cessation, and the path leading to that cessation.
Four postures	Walking, standing, sitting, and lying down - the ordinary bodily positions in which mindfulness and non-harming are to be practiced.
Four Shared Traits	An unusual English rendering of the Chinese "four equal or immeasurable [attitudes]." In this passage it most naturally points to loving-kindness, compassion, appreciative joy, and equanimity extended impartially to all beings.
Four Torrents; Four Flows	Desire, continued existence, wrong views, and ignorance, pictured as strong currents carrying beings through saṃsāra.
Four Universal Vows	To save limitless beings, end limitless afflictions, learn limitless Dharma teachings, and attain unsurpassed Buddhahood.
Four Unobstructed Wisdoms	Unhindered understanding of meaning, teachings, language or expression, and confident explanation.
Fourfold training lists within the Thirty-Seven Factors	The Four Foundations of Mindfulness, Four Proper Exertions, and Four Bases or Means of Accomplishment: practices for mindful observation, wholesome effort, and focused spiritual power.
Friends and foes as equal; friends and foes benefit together	Impartial compassion: wishing liberation for those one likes and those with whom one has conflict. It does not require ignoring present danger or abandoning wise boundaries.
Front or back orifice	Blunt wording in a celibacy passage for sexual penetration involving the genitals or anus. It is describing violations of monastic "pure conduct," not introducing a separate meditation term.
Fruits; fruitions; results and effects	The outcomes of causes, especially the pleasant or painful results attributed to intentional karma and spiritual practice.
Ganges sands; grains of dust	Stock images for a number so vast that it is effectively beyond counting.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Gate of Sweet Dew	A poetic name for liberating Buddhist teaching. Sweet dew or nectar represents the “deathless” relief of nirvāṇa.
Golden Sage; King of Awakening; Tamer	Honorific images for a Buddha: radiant with wisdom, sovereign in awakening, and able to guide difficult beings.
Guanyin	The Chinese name of Avalokiteśvara, the bodhisattva of compassion. A feminine Guanyin image and a masculine Indian Avalokiteśvara image represent the same bodhisattva in different cultural forms.
Heart Sūtra	A short and influential Mahāyāna scripture teaching the emptiness of the five aggregates and all fixed categories, while presenting wisdom beyond attachment as the way through suffering.
Heart Sūtra mantra; *gate gate pāragate pārasaṃgate bodhi svāhā*	A closing formula commonly understood as “gone, gone, gone beyond, gone completely beyond, awakening, svāhā”. It points to wisdom passing beyond clinging and fear, not to physical travel.
Heart Sūtra’s “no eyes … no path … no attainment”	Speech from the ultimate perspective of emptiness: none of these categories exists independently or can be possessed as a fixed thing. It is not a denial that eyes, ethical practice, or the path function in everyday life.
Heavenly or celestial eyes	A traditional supernormal ability to see far away, through obstructions, and into beings’ karmic destinies. It is also used figuratively for vision beyond ordinary sight.
Hell wardens; Ox-Headed Warden	Fearsome figures in Buddhist hell narratives who administer karmic punishment. They personify the unavoidable consequences described by the text.
Homage	A respectful salutation expressing reverence, gratitude, and willingness to learn.
Honored Kanaka	The saintly monk in the Water Repentance origin story who directs Wuda to the samādhi spring. He is traditionally identified with the arhat Kanakavatsa.
Hundred and One Essential Items	A traditional general expression for the many ordinary necessities of daily life, not necessarily a literal checklist of exactly 101 objects here.
Hundred Disagreements	A stock phrase for the many speculative positions produced by combining conceptual claims. “Ending” them means going beyond fruitless argument, not merely winning a debate.
Hungry ghost	A being in a painful realm characterised by extreme, unsatisfied hunger and thirst; a symbol and cosmological result of consuming greed and stinginess.
Iconography; recognition attribute	The visual conventions used to identify a sacred figure in art. For example, a wisdom sword often points to Mañjuśrī and a ringed staff often points to Kṣitigarbha. Attributes vary across regions, so one object by itself may not settle an identification.
Icchantika	A person described in some Mahāyāna texts as having cut off or rejected the roots of goodness and the wish for awakening. Later traditions debate whether anyone is permanently incapable of Buddhahood.
Ignorance	Not merely lack of information, but a basic misperception of reality - especially taking impermanent, conditioned experience to be a fixed self or lasting source of satisfaction.
Imperial and dynastic references: Western Han, Tang, Song, and Yongle reign	Historical markers locating the origin legend and its later transmission in Chinese history. They are not Buddhist stages or realms.
Impermanence	The fact that all conditioned things change and do not remain under complete control.
Incense Cloud Canopy	A ritual image in which incense smoke becomes a vast, protective offering above the assembly. It is also the title of the bodhisattvas invoked in that praise.
Inherent nature	A fixed, independent essence that something would possess by itself. The text says transgressions lack such a nature because they arise and cease through conditions.
Inverted views; inverted dream-like delusions	Seeing reality backwards - for example, treating the impermanent as permanent, suffering as lasting happiness, the non-self as a self, or the impure as pure.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Jambudvīpa; Jambudvīpan lifespan	In ancient Buddhist cosmology, the southern continent around Mount Meru, understood as the human world in which we live.
Join the palms	Place the hands together at the chest as a gesture of respect and collected attention.
Kalaviṅka	A mythical bird celebrated for an extraordinarily beautiful voice; the Buddha's speech is compared to its song.
Kalpa	An immensely long cosmic period. Phrases such as "kalpas as numerous as dust" mean an inconceivably long time.
Kāmalā disease	An old medical term generally associated with jaundice. In the origin story it afflicts the sick monk whom Zhixuan compassionately nurses; it is separate from Wuda's later human-faced tumour.
Karma and consciousness are suddenly empty	A realisation that karma and consciousness lack a permanent independent essence. It does not mean that ethical consequences are casually cancelled or that awareness becomes literal nothingness.
Karma; karmic action	Intentional action of body, speech, or mind and the causal pattern it creates. Karma is not simply fate, punishment, or everything that happens.
Karmic conditions	Circumstances shaped in part by earlier intentional actions and interacting present causes.
Karmic obstacles; karmic obstructions	Effects of past or present actions that make ethical conduct, meditation, understanding, or favourable circumstances harder.
Karmic retribution; residual retribution	The maturing result of intentional action. "Residual" retribution means effects that remain even after the main karmic result has been experienced.
Kindness, compassion, joy, and equanimity	The Four Limitless Minds: wishing happiness, wishing freedom from suffering, rejoicing in others' good, and caring impartially.
King Yāma	The judge of the dead in Buddhist cosmology, who examines actions and assigns hell consequences. He is not an all-powerful creator or eternal devil.
Kṣitigarbha Bodhisattva	"Earth Treasury," the bodhisattva especially associated in East Asian Buddhism with immense vows, rescuing beings in painful realms, filial gratitude and care for the deceased. The familiar saying about not becoming a Buddha until the hells are empty is a traditional summary; the exact sentence does not appear in the cited BDK translation of the *Sūtra on the Past Vows*.
Kumbhāṇḍa	A class of misshapen, potentially harmful spirit in Indian and Buddhist cosmology.
Lapis lazuli; beryl radiance	A brilliant blue precious-stone image associated with Medicine Master Buddha's radiance and pure land. A blue body is common in Tibetan Medicine Buddha art, but Chinese and Korean images may use other colours or rely on a bowl, staff or assembly for identification.
Last meal offered to a Buddha entering nirvāṇa	An allusion to the honoured final meal offered to Śākyamuni before his death and final nirvāṇa. The vow means wishing always to have the rare opportunity to support a Buddha.
Liberation; other shore	Freedom from affliction, suffering, and the cycle of rebirth. Crossing an ocean or reaching the "other shore" is a common metaphor for attaining it.
Liturgy	A fixed order of communal worship, chanting, movement, confession, and dedication.
Lotus birth; born through transformation	Rebirth in a Pure Land pictured as appearing within a lotus rather than being born through an ordinary womb.
Lotus with the practitioner's name	A later Pure Land devotional image in which faith, vows, name-recitation and practice nourish a lotus in Sukhāvatī associated with the practitioner, sometimes pictured as bearing the practitioner's name. This detail is not stated in the Water Repentance or the shorter *Amitābha Sūtra*.
Lotus Pool or Great Oceanic Assembly	The vast gathering of Amitābha, bodhisattvas, and Pure Land practitioners, poetically pictured around a lotus pool.
Loving-kindness	The sincere wish that beings be happy and encounter the causes of happiness.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Mahāsthāmaprāpta Bodhisattva	The bodhisattva “Arrival of Great Strength,” representing the power of wisdom and mindful recollection of Amitābha in Pure Land Buddhism. In the familiar triad, Mahāsthāmaprāpta and Avalokiteśvara attend Amitābha.
Mahāvyūha Bodhisattva	A bodhisattva invoked in the repeated litany. The English text supplies no separate narrative or visual attributes. “Great Adornment” and “Great Array” are cautious readings of the name, not a secure biography.
Mahāyāna; Great Vehicle	A broad Buddhist tradition centred on the bodhisattva path and full Buddhahood for the benefit of all beings. Chinese Buddhism, including this liturgy, is Mahāyāna.
Maitreya Bodhisattva; Maitreya Buddha	Maitreya is understood as a bodhisattva dwelling in Tuṣita now and as the Buddha who will awaken and teach in this world after Śākyamuni's dispensation has disappeared. The two titles describe present and future roles, not two figures. His name is connected with loving-kindness.
Manifested Buddha or bodhisattva; trillion-fold bodies; thirty-two responses	Different forms that an awakened being is said to display according to beings’ needs. The numbers emphasise limitless compassionate adaptability.
Mañjuśrī Bodhisattva	The bodhisattva who personifies profound wisdom. He is often shown with a sword that cuts through ignorance.
Mantra	A sacred formula recited for concentration, protection, purification, or blessing. The sound may be preserved even when a straightforward word-for-word translation is unavailable.
Mantra or dhāraṇī printed in Latin letters	A transliteration of sacred sounds, not an English sentence. In this liturgy the sound has often travelled through an Indic original, Chinese phonetic characters and a living Chinese chanting tradition.
Marks and characteristics; Thirty-Two Marks and Eighty Signs; ūrṇā	Idealised bodily features said to display a Buddha’s accumulated virtue. The ūrṇā is the white curl or mark between the eyebrows, sometimes poetically called jade.
Master Wuda Zhixuan	The eminent Chinese monk to whom the Water Repentance is attributed. In the origin legend, a painful human-faced tumour reveals an old karmic grievance and is cleansed with samādhi water.
Medicine Master Buddha	See **Bhaiṣajyaguru**. The Water Repentance invokes this Buddha in the Noon Offering with the devotional title “disaster-eradicating and longevity-extending”.
Memorial Altar Dedication	A ritual section directing merit towards people who have died and aspiring for their peaceful rebirth, especially in Amitābha’s Pure Land.
Merit and virtue; blessings	Beneficial spiritual qualities and results cultivated through ethical action, generosity, meditation, wisdom, and ritual. “Merit” is not a commercial credit that can simply purchase salvation.
Middle Way	Avoiding the extremes of self-indulgence and self-torment and, philosophically, avoiding rigid claims of absolute existence or absolute nonexistence.
Mind consciousness; mind organ	The mental faculty that notices ideas, memories, emotions, and other mental objects, treated in Buddhism as a sixth sense alongside the five physical senses.
Mind’s eye; wisdom life; wisdom root	Metaphors for the capacity to understand the Dharma. Afflictions “blind the mind’s eye” or “cut the wisdom root” when they undermine that capacity.
Mount Meru; Four Continents	The central mountain and surrounding human worlds in ancient Buddhist cosmology. They provide the traditional map used in many scriptures and rituals.
Mt. Jiulong; Nine Peaks; Western Shu; Pengzhou	Place names in the Wuda origin story, describing the mountain region where he seeks Honored Kanaka and finds the healing spring.
Mudrā; hand gesture	A formal hand position in Buddhist ritual and art. A mudrā can help identify an image, such as Śākyamuni's earth-touching gesture or one form of Vairocana's wisdom fist, but the same figure may use different gestures in different traditions.
Nāga	A powerful serpent or dragon-like being associated with water, treasure, and protection of the Dharma.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Nam Mô A Di Đà Phật; Namo Amituofo	Vietnamese and Mandarin forms of “Homage to Amitābha Buddha”. Reciting the name recollects Amitābha and expresses refuge and aspiration for rebirth in Sukhāvatī.
National Master	An honorific given by an emperor to an eminent Buddhist teacher who served or advised the state.
Nine Conditions	The Chinese term can refer to nine supports by which sensory consciousness arises, such as a functioning faculty, an object, light or space, attention, and continuity. Commentators on this exact repentance passage disagree about whether that technical list is intended, so the safest beginner meaning is “the many conditions through which confused consciousness and action arise.”
Nine Difficulties; Nine Vexations	The PDF’s “Difficulties” translates a term for nine occasions of resentment: thinking that someone harmed, harms, or will harm oneself; did so to someone one loves; or helped, helps, or will help someone one opposes. It shows anger multiplying across self/other and past/present/future.
Nine Empty Concentrations	A sequence of deep meditations, usually the Four Dhyānas, four formless attainments, and cessation. “Empty” here does not mean blank unconsciousness at every stage.
Nine Fetters	A list of bonds such as craving, anger, pride, ignorance, wrong views, clinging, doubt, envy, and stinginess that keep beings tied to saṃsāra.
Nine grades or stages of lotus blossoms	Nine traditional levels of rebirth in Amitābha’s Pure Land, reflecting different degrees of faith, practice, and realisation.
Nine obscurities covering the land	A poetic or cosmological image for widespread darkness dispelled by the Buddha’s teaching. The English text does not identify nine individual obscurities.
Nine Orifices	The body’s nine openings: two eyes, two ears, two nostrils, mouth, urinary opening, and anus. The contemplation emphasises the body’s physical, non-idealised nature.
Nine Severing Wisdoms; Nine Knowledges of Abandonment	An Abhidharma analysis of nine completed acts of abandoning groups of afflictions as insight penetrates the Four Noble Truths across the desire, form, and formless realms. “Wisdom” here means verified liberating knowledge that a particular bondage has been cut off, not nine clever ideas.
Ninety-Eight Afflictions; One Hundred and Eight Afflictions	Traditional comprehensive counts of defilements, produced by classifying basic afflictions across realms and stages of practice. “108 afflictions” is also a common symbolic total for the many ways the mind becomes troubled.
Nirvāṇa	Liberation in which greed, hatred, ignorance, and the causes of rebirth have been extinguished. It is not simply a heavenly place.
Noble Eightfold Path	Right view, intention, speech, action, livelihood, effort, mindfulness, and concentration - the practical path leading to the end of suffering.
Non-arising; state or patience of non-arising	Insight that phenomena do not arise as independent, permanent things. “Patience” here means a stable, unshaken acceptance of that realisation.
Non-retrogressing bodhisattva; non-retrogression	A stage from which progress towards Buddhahood will no longer fall back. In Pure Land aspiration, it means gaining conditions that keep practice moving towards awakening rather than repeatedly losing its direction.
Non-self	The teaching that no permanent, independent, fully controlling “I” can be found in the changing body and mind. It does not deny ordinary personhood or ethical responsibility.
Noon Offering Before the Buddhas	A midday food-offering service addressed to Buddhas, bodhisattvas, the Sangha, and - in expanded dedication - all beings.
Oṃ; hūṃ; svāhā; hoḥ	Common mantra syllables. *Oṃ* opens a sacred formula; *hūṃ* gathers or seals intention; *svāhā* marks offering or fulfilment; and *hoḥ* is a concluding ritual exclamation. Their function is wider than any single English substitute.
Ocean of the Flower Treasury; Lotus Treasury	Vast, interpenetrating Buddha-realms associated especially with Vairocana and the *Flower Adornment Sūtra*. In the liturgy they evoke the cosmic scope of awakening.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
One Reality	The single, undivided truth of things as they are, beyond the fragmented way ignorance ordinarily perceives them.
One Vehicle	The Mahāyāna teaching that the Buddha's various paths ultimately lead towards the one complete awakening of Buddhahood.
One-child mind of compassion	Caring for every sentient being with the urgency and tenderness a loving parent gives an only child.
Outflow	A deep mental taint or "leak," such as craving or ignorance, that continually feeds suffering and rebirth.
Ox-Headed Warden, flaming pills, sword wheels, and other hell imagery	Deliberately shocking images of karmic suffering. They function as moral warning and cosmological description within the liturgy, not as instructions for human punishment.
Pāramitā; perfection; other shore of pāramitā	A virtue developed to the level that carries a bodhisattva to awakening. Pāramitā is traditionally associated with "reaching the other shore."
Past Seven Buddhas: Vipaśyin, Śikhin, Viśvabhū, Krakucchanda, Kanakamuni, Kāśyapa, and Śākyamuni	A traditional succession of six Buddhas before Śākyamuni, followed by Śākyamuni as the seventh. They are invoked as witnesses and sources of the Dharma.
Patience of equality	Patient stability based on seeing beings and phenomena without rigid discrimination or favoritism. It does not mean passively accepting abuse.
Perfect Awakening, Wondrous Awakening, and Equal Awakening Stage Bodhisattvas	Titles for extremely advanced stages near Buddhahood in East Asian Mahāyāna systems. The ritual addresses all bodhisattvas at those levels collectively.
Permanence, bliss, self-nature, and purity	In Mahāyāna language, four positive qualities of complete nirvāṇa. "Self" or "self-nature" here points to freedom from the false ego and from change-driven suffering, not to an ordinary eternal personal soul.
Pillars and crossbeams of the Buddhadharma	A building metaphor for people who strongly support, preserve, and transmit Buddhist teaching and community.
Prabhūtaratna Buddha	"Many Treasures Buddha," who appears in a jewelled stūpa in Chapter 11 of the *Lotus Sūtra*, praises Śākyamuni's teaching as true and shares his seat with him. The paired Buddhas in a stūpa are a common recognition scene.
Prajñā	Deep wisdom that directly understands reality, especially impermanence, non-self, dependent arising, and emptiness.
Prajñāpāramitā; Mahāprajñāpāramitā	The "perfection of wisdom," the insight into emptiness that guides the bodhisattva path. "Mahā" means great.
Pratyekabuddha	A "solitary Buddha" who awakens to dependent origination without a Buddha teaching in the world, but does not establish a broad teaching dispensation.
Precepts	Ethical training commitments intended to prevent harm and support clarity, concentration, and compassion.
Proper Dharma; honoured Dharma	Respectful terms for teachings considered authentic and conducive to awakening. "Proper" contrasts with distorted teaching, not with ordinary etiquette.
Proper sensation	The preface's unusual English gloss for samādhi. In context it means an undistracted, rightly settled awareness, close to "proper concentration," not a particular physical sensation.
Prophecy or prediction of awakening	A Buddha's assurance that a practitioner will attain Buddhahood in the future, often including the future Buddha's name or realm.
Prostration; "touch our heads to the floor"	A full bow expressing humility, reverence, and the letting go of pride. Three prostrations are a common ritual set.
Pure Land; Western Pure Land; Realm of Ultimate Bliss	A realm established through Amitābha Buddha's vows where conditions strongly support progress towards awakening.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Pure precepts; precepts, concentration, and wisdom	Ethical discipline purified of intentional violation, together with meditative stability and insight - the three core trainings of Buddhist practice.
Rājagṛha; Mount Vipula	Rājagṛha, present-day Rajgir in India, was an important city during the Buddha's life. Nearby Mount Vipula is used in the text's vast comparison of bones accumulated through rebirth.
Rākṣasa	An ogre-like, often flesh-eating spirit in Buddhist stories. "Rākṣasas of Affliction" personifies destructive mental states as predators.
Rebirth in borderlands; three evils	"Borderlands" is an old Buddhist term for places where the Dharma was believed unavailable; it should not be read as a modern judgment of ethnic worth. "Three evils" here most likely means the three lower realms.
Rebirth in future lives	The continuation of conditioned existence after death through karmic causation. Buddhism generally does not explain it as an unchanged soul moving from body to body.
Rebirth in the Pure Land Dhāraṇī	A Sanskrit-derived purification and aspiration chant honouring Amitābha Tathāgata. Its clearest words refer to homage, Amitābha and the "deathless" nectar of liberation; not every transmitted word has a secure literal translation.
Refuge; Three Refuges; "return our lives in refuge"	Entrusting one's life and direction to the Buddha as teacher, the Dharma as path, and the Sangha as community. "Return our lives" is a literal, devotional way of saying "take wholehearted refuge."
Remorse and shame	Healthy recognition of harm: remorse looks honestly at one's own action, while moral shame includes concern for integrity and the effect on others. The aim is reform, not permanent self-hatred.
Repentance and reform	Acknowledging harmful actions, regretting them, making amends where possible, and resolving not to repeat them. The added word "reform" stresses changed conduct, not confession alone.
Resultative obstruction	Painful circumstances or rebirths understood as matured karmic results that obstruct practice. It is the third of the Three Obstructions.
Retributive body	The present body viewed as a result of past karma and as subject to ageing, illness, and death.
Ritual collective bodhisattva titles: Incense Cloud Canopy, Precious Uḍumbara Blossom, Universal Offering, Pure Cool Ground, Dhyāna Bliss Treasury, and Ascending the Path of Clouds	Devotional names addressing groups of bodhisattvas associated with the particular praise, offering, dedication, or closing action. They need not each be read as the biography of one separately identified historical person.
Ripa ripate	The opening of the Seven Buddhas Offence-Extinguishing Mantra. It is a transmitted sound formula rather than an English phrase. The overall purpose is purification and the clearing of karmic obstruction; the individual syllables cannot all be translated responsibly.
Sacred and ordinary beings	"Sacred" means awakened or highly realised beings; "ordinary" means those still governed by ignorance and affliction.
Śakra; Emperor Śakra; Lord of the Devas	The ruler of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three in Buddhist cosmology. He supports the Dharma but remains a conditioned, impermanent celestial being.
Śākyamuni Buddha; our teacher	The historical Buddha of our world, Siddhārtha Gautama, who awakened in India and taught the path followed in Buddhism.
Samādhi	Deep meditative collectedness in which the mind is stable, clear, and not scattered by ordinary reactions.
Samādhi water; Dharma water	In the origin story, spring water blessed by meditative and spiritual power; more broadly, a metaphor for the Dharma cleansing hatred, guilt, and karmic obstruction.
Samantabhadra Bodhisattva; King of Vows; Honored Universal Auspiciousness	The bodhisattva who represents great practice and vows, especially homage, offering, repentance, learning, helping beings, and dedicating merit.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Saṃsāra; cycle or wheel of birth and death; transmigration	Repeated conditioned birth and death driven by ignorance, craving, and karma.
Sanctuary of Awakening; repentance sanctuary; repentance altar	The consecrated ritual space and the practice performed there. “Sanctuary” can refer both to the physical hall or altar and to the full repentance ceremony.
Sangha	Most specifically, the ordained Buddhist community; as the third of the Triple Gem, it can also mean the noble community that has realised the teaching.
Sanghārāma; Sanghārāma Bodhisattvas	A monastery or monastic precinct; in East Asian ritual, “Sanghārāma Bodhisattvas” are guardian figures who protect monasteries and their communities.
Śāriputra	One of Śākyamuni Buddha’s leading disciples, renowned for wisdom. The Heart Sūtra addresses its explanation of emptiness to him.
Sarvajña; omniscience	Literally “all-knowing.” In this context it means a Buddha’s complete liberating knowledge of phenomena and the ways to guide beings.
Śāstra	A systematic Buddhist treatise or commentary that explains and analyzes teachings.
Scroll	One major division or volume of the liturgy. The three PDFs correspond to the upper, middle, and lower scrolls.
Secret verses	Mantras or dhāraṇīs recited in their traditional sounds. “Secret” suggests esoteric or spiritually potent language, not a hidden conspiracy.
Self-nature	Depending on context, either the mistakenly imagined fixed essence of a person or the deeper awakened nature spoken of in Mahāyāna. It should not be assumed to mean an eternal personal soul.
Sending-Off the Sacred	A closing ritual praise that respectfully concludes the presence or attention of the Buddhas, bodhisattvas, and protectors invoked during the service.
Sentient being	Any being capable of conscious experience and suffering. In Buddhist cosmology this includes humans, animals, devas, ghosts, and hell beings.
Seven Buddhas Offense-Extinguishing Mantra	A purification chant recited at the end of each scroll, beginning *ripa ripate*. The title states its reliable ritual purpose; the complete transmitted wording is not secure Classical Sanskrit and should not be forced into a word-for-word English sentence.
Seven Expedient Means	Seven preparatory stages towards direct insight: three broad stages of worthiness followed by Warmth, Summit, Acceptance, and Supreme Attribute.
Seven Factors or Limbs of Awakening	Mindfulness, investigation, energy, joy, tranquility, concentration, and equanimity - qualities cultivated together as awakening develops.
Seven Kinds of Mind	The seven attitudes listed in Scroll One: remorse and shame, fear of consequences, dispassion, bodhi mind, equality towards friends and foes, gratitude for the Buddha’s kindness, and understanding the empty nature of transgressions.
Seven limbs of complete precepts	The seven bodily and verbal branches of ethical conduct: not killing, stealing, or engageing in sexual misconduct, and not using false, divisive, harsh, or frivolous speech. They are the first seven of the Ten Wholesome Deeds; the remaining three concern the mind.
Seven Outflows	A technical list concerning ways defilements continue to “leak” through unguarded living and ways they are abandoned. The PDF names the group but does not give its seven members.
Seven Purities; Lotus of Seven Purities	Seven linked purifications: ethical conduct, mind, view, overcoming doubt, knowing what is and is not the path, knowing the course of practice, and liberating knowledge that severs defilement. The lotus is a poetic image for these purities unfolding through practice.
Seven Tendencies	Latent inclinations towards sensual desire, aversion, views, doubt, conceit, craving for continued existence, and ignorance.
Seven Treasures	A conventional set of precious materials, often including gold, silver, crystal, beryl, coral or pearl, and other gems; the exact list varies.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Six Consciousnesses	Visual, auditory, olfactory, taste, touch, and mental consciousness arising when a sense organ meets its object.
Six Dusts; six sense objects	Sights, sounds, smells, tastes, tangible objects, and mental objects. “Dusts” suggests that attachment to them can cloud the mind; the objects are not inherently evil.
Six Emotions; Six Perceptions; Six Sensations; Six Volitions; Six Passions; Six Doubts	Several sixfold analyses of how experience is noticed, felt, interpreted, intended, craved, or doubted through the six senses. The PDF names these technical groups without listing each set.
Six Faculties; six sense organs; six senses	Eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind - the six capacities through which experience occurs. Each has its object and consciousness: eye-forms-visual consciousness, ear-sounds-auditory consciousness, nose-odours-olfactory consciousness, tongue-tastes-taste consciousness, body-tangible objects-tactile consciousness, and mind-mental objects-mental consciousness.
Six fasting days; three long fasting periods	Traditional lay observance times for stricter precepts, vegetarian practice, repentance, and merit-making: six days each lunar month and three longer periods during the year. Calendrical details vary.
Six Pāramitās; Six Perfections	Generosity, ethical discipline, patience, diligent effort, meditative concentration, and wisdom, cultivated for the benefit of all beings.
Six points of reverent harmony	Communal harmony in bodily conduct, speech, thought, ethical discipline, understanding, and fair sharing of material support.
Six recollections	Recollecting the Buddha, Dharma, Sangha, ethical conduct, generosity, and devas or the wholesome qualities represented by them.
Six Spiritual Powers	Traditional abilities arising from advanced practice: extraordinary movement or manifestation, heavenly sight, heavenly hearing, reading minds, recalling past lives, and knowing the ending of the outflows.
Six types of kin	A general traditional expression for one’s close family relations. Exact enumerations vary; in this liturgy it means the wider family, not six named supernatural beings.
Six Wondrous Gates	A meditation sequence usually explained as counting the breath, following it, stabilizing the mind, observing, turning awareness back, and purification.
Sixteen improper livelihoods	An ancient list of occupations organized around harm. It includes raising or buying animals for slaughter, fishing, hunting and trapping, robbery, execution or punitive confinement, malicious divisive speech, and coercive control of animals. The underlying principle is to avoid work built on killing, cruelty, exploitation, or deliberate harm.
Sixteen Understandings and Views	Sixteen aspects of insight into the Four Noble Truths - four ways of understanding each truth.
Sixty-Two Views	A traditional catalogue of speculative theories about self and world, especially eternalist and annihilationist positions, treated as traps of attachment.
Spiritual response; efficacious	A perceived sign that sincere practice has met with the compassionate activity of Buddhas or bodhisattvas. “Efficacious” means believed to produce a real religious effect.
Śramaṇa	A renunciant spiritual practitioner; in this Buddhist text it usually means a monk or nun.
Śrāvaka	Literally a “hearer”: a disciple who reaches liberation by hearing and practicing a Buddha’s teaching. Mahāyāna texts contrast this goal with the bodhisattva’s aim of full Buddhahood.
Śrotāpanna; stream-enterer	The first of four stages of arhat awakening, at which a practitioner has entered the irreversible stream towards liberation.
Stūpa	A sacred mound or monument that enshrines relics, scriptures, or associations with a Buddha or other revered teacher.
Suffering; dissatisfaction	Renderings of *duḥkha*: obvious pain as well as the deeper unreliability and inability of conditioned life to provide permanent satisfaction.
Supreme caste	Traditional Indian social-ranking language used in the Pure Land vow. In context it expresses a wish for an honoured and unobstructed rebirth in Amitābha Buddha’s land.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Sūtra	A scripture or discourse presenting Buddhist teaching, traditionally connected with the Buddha's words.
Sweet dew; ambrosia	A symbol of the "deathless" freedom of nirvāṇa and the refreshing, life-giving quality of the Dharma.
Tathāgata	"Thus Come One" or "Thus Gone One," a title a Buddha uses for one who has fully realised reality.
Tathāgata's robes; armor of patience; bed of fearlessness; seat of empty phenomena; food of Dharma joy	Poetic images for living within the Buddha's teaching, being protected by patient endurance, being free from fear, being grounded in emptiness, and being inwardly nourished by the Dharma.
Ten Afflictions	Commonly greed, anger, ignorance, pride, doubt, belief in a self, extreme views, denial of causality, attachment to wrong views, and attachment to rites as sufficient.
Ten Bonds; Ten Ensnaring Afflictions	Ten states that wrap around or entangle the mind: lack of inner shame, lack of concern about wrongdoing before others, envy, stinginess, agitated remorse, drowsiness, restlessness, mental dullness, rage, and concealment of one's faults.
Ten Dedications	Ten stages on the bodhisattva path in which cultivated goodness is turned towards all beings and full awakening.
Ten Directions	North, south, east, west, the four intermediate directions, above, and below - a ritual way of saying everywhere.
Ten Illuminations	Ten forms of far-reaching bodhisattva knowledge in the *Flower Adornment Sūtra*, including knowledge of other minds, karmic continuity and rebirth, past and future, languages and meanings, and the nature of phenomena. They express unobstructed wisdom rather than literal lamps.
Ten Pāramitās	The Six Perfections plus skilful means, vows, spiritual power, and knowledge.
Ten Powers	Ten forms of a Buddha's complete knowledge, including causes and effects, karmic results, beings' capacities, meditative paths, past lives, rebirths, and liberation.
Ten Practices	Ten stages of compassionate bodhisattva conduct within the traditional fifty-two-stage path, following the Ten Abodes and preceding the Ten Dedications.
Ten Unwholesome Deeds or Karmas	Killing, stealing, sexual misconduct; false, divisive, harsh, and frivolous speech; greed, ill will, and wrong views.
Ten Vows	In this liturgy the phrase generally points to Samantabhadra's great vows: homage, praise, offering, repentance, rejoicing, requesting teaching, asking Buddhas to remain, learning, helping beings, and dedicating merit.
Ten Wisdoms	Ten analytical and liberating knowledges, including understanding Dharma, comparison, conventional life, others' minds, each Noble Truth, the ending of outflows, and non-arising.
The Thirty-Seven Factors of Awakening	A combined framework of Four Foundations of Mindfulness, Four Proper Exertions, Four Bases of Accomplishment, Five Faculties, Five Powers, Seven Factors of Awakening, and the Noble Eightfold Path.
The Three Thousand Etiquettes; Eighty Thousand Regulations	Large conventional numbers for the detailed rules of mindful monastic conduct. They stress care in everyday behaviour rather than requiring a beginner to locate 83,000 separate rules.
Thirty-six parts of the body	A contemplation listing bodily materials and organs to counter idealization, sensual attachment, and belief that the body is a pure, permanent self.
Three assemblies under the Dragon Blossom Tree	Three future gatherings at which Maitreya Buddha is expected to teach and liberate vast numbers of beings after awakening beneath the Dragon Blossom Tree.
Three Awakenings	Self-awakening, helping others awaken, and the complete perfection of both awakening and conduct. The triad describes the full accomplishment of a Buddha.
Three Bodies	The Dharma body as ultimate reality, the reward or enjoyment body experienced by advanced bodhisattvas, and manifested bodies that appear in worlds to teach.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Three Contemplations	Contemplating emptiness, provisional or conditioned existence, and the Middle Way that holds both without clinging to either extreme.
Three Delusions	In an East Asian Mahāyāna framework: delusions of views and desires, the innumerable misunderstandings that obstruct helping beings, and fundamental ignorance about reality.
Three Insights; Three Understandings	Knowledge of past lives, knowledge of beings' deaths and rebirths, and knowledge that one's own outflows have ended. The two English labels appear to point to this same traditional triad.
Three Karmas	Intentional action through body, speech, and mind. "Purifying the three karmas" means bringing all three into ethical and mindful alignment.
Three kinds of light	Sunlight, moonlight, and starlight. The hell passage imagines a darkness in which none of these three natural lights can be recognised.
Three Lower Realms	The animal, hungry ghost, and hell realms, regarded as especially painful rebirths.
Three minds	In the immediate context, most likely the mind as obscured by greed, anger, and ignorance, since those three afflictions are named in the lines that follow. The source uses a compressed poetic label rather than a formal enumeration.
Three Obstructions	Afflictive obstruction in the mind, karmic obstruction created by action, and resultative obstruction when painful consequences mature.
Three Outflows	Deep taints associated with sensual craving, craving for continued existence, and ignorance, which keep experience "flowing out" into rebirth.
Three Periods; three time periods	Past, present, and future. "Buddhas of the three periods" means Buddhas of all times.
Three Poisons	Greed, anger or hatred, and ignorance - the three basic causes of harmful action and suffering.
Three Realms	The desire realm, form realm, and formless realm - the full range of conditioned rebirth in this cosmology.
Three Samādhis	Three liberating concentrations: emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness or aimlessness.
Three Sufferings	Painful suffering, suffering caused by change, and the pervasive unsatisfactoriness of all conditioned existence.
Three timings of karmic retribution	Results may mature in the present life, the next life, or a more distant future life. The passage uses this to explain why present fortune does not always match present conduct.
Three turnings of the Dharma wheel; third turning	A way of grouping the Buddha's teachings into three major cycles or emphases. In the closing ritual, "third turning" also resonates with completing the third scroll and session.
Three Unstained Learnings	Ethical discipline, meditative concentration, and wisdom practiced free of the "outflows" that perpetuate rebirth.
Three Vehicles	Paths associated with the śrāvaka, pratyekabuddha, and bodhisattva. Mahāyāna texts often teach that these are ultimately gathered into the One Vehicle.
Three virtues and six flavors of food	A traditional ideal offering: food is clean, gentle or wholesome, and prepared in accordance with the Dharma, with the six tastes of bitter, sour, sweet, hot or pungent, salty, and mild.
Three Vows	A named set of aspirations in Scroll One. The English text does not identify the three, and several different Buddhist triads are called "Three Vows."
Three Wisdoms	Wisdom that knows general reality, wisdom that knows the different paths and needs of beings, and a Buddha's complete knowledge of all aspects.
Transformation of Food, Sweet Dew, and Universal Offering Dhāraṇīs	Offering chants understood respectively to multiply or transform food, purify it into liberating nectar, and extend the offering universally to sacred beings and beings in every realm.
Trichiliocosm; three-thousandfold world system	A vast traditional Buddhist cosmos containing an enormous number of worlds. It does not mean only three thousand planets.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Triple Gem	The Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha: the awakened teacher, the teaching and path, and the community that preserves and realises it.
Triple Invocation	Calling a sacred name three times to begin or focus a ritual section.
True Thusness; One Truth; true nature of reality	Reality as it is before it is distorted by craving, aversion, and fixed concepts. Also called suchness.
Tuṣita Heaven	The “Joyful” heaven where Maitreya is traditionally understood to dwell and teach as a bodhisattva before his future birth and awakening in this world. It remains part of Buddhist cosmology and should not be confused with Amitābha's Sukhāvatī.
Twelve Contacts; Twelve Sense Bases; Twelve Elements	The PDF’s “Twelve Contacts” translates the twelve entrances or bases: the six faculties - eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind - plus their six objects - forms, sounds, odours, tastes, tangible objects, and mental objects. Their meeting provides the conditions for the corresponding consciousness.
Twelve Links of Dependent Origination	Ignorance, formations, consciousness, name-and-form, six sense bases, contact, feeling, craving, clinging, becoming, birth, and ageing-and-death - the cycle explaining how suffering continues.
Twelve-aspect Dharma Wheel	The Four Noble Truths each understood in three phases: recognising the truth, knowing the task it requires, and knowing that the task has been completed.
Twenty-Five Aspects of Self	A technical catalogue of ways a person can mistakenly identify a permanent self with body and mind. The English text gives the total but not the twenty-five individual views.
Two kinds of inverted views	Most likely distorted perception and distorted belief: first experiencing or imagining a sense object in a confused way, then forming and defending an incorrect view about it. Both make what is unstable and conditioned appear fixed or self-sufficient.
Two obstructions	Afflictive obstruction, which binds beings to suffering, and cognitive obstruction, which prevents complete knowledge and Buddhahood.
Two Truths	Conventional truth - how things function in everyday dependent reality - and ultimate truth - their emptiness of fixed, independent essence.
Udrakarāmaputra; state of neither thinking nor not-thinking	Udrakarāmaputra is the teacher called Uddaka Rāmaputta in many English sources. The state is the highest of the four formless concentrations, subtle but still within saṃsāra.
Uḍumbara blossom	A legendary flower said to appear extremely rarely, used as an image for the rare appearance of a Buddha or other auspicious event.
Upāsaka	A male lay Buddhist who has formally taken refuge and usually undertakes the Five Precepts. The corresponding term for a woman is upāsikā.
Vaipulya	“Extensive” Mahāyāna scriptures. “Slandering the Vaipulya” means rejecting or denigrating those expansive Mahāyāna teachings.
Vairocana Buddha	The cosmic Buddha of all-pervading illumination, especially important in the *Flower Adornment Sūtra* and East Asian esoteric traditions.
Vajra; vajra body	Vajra means diamond or thunderbolt and symbolizes indestructibility. A “vajra body” is a wish for an incorruptible awakened body, not an ordinary body made of stone.
Vimalakīrti Sūtra	A Mahāyāna scripture centred on the wise layman Vimalakīrti; here it is cited for honest confession and nonconcealment of faults.
Vinaya	The body of monastic discipline: rules, procedures, and ethical training for Buddhist monks and nuns.
Violent ghost of impermanence	A personification of sudden death and uncontrollable change. It is meant to create urgency for practice, not to identify a medically observable being.
Virtuous friend; virtuous advisor	A trustworthy spiritual teacher or companion who encourages ethical conduct, correct understanding, and practice. Also called a spiritual friend.

Term / Phrase	Simple explanation
Virtuous roots	Deeply established wholesome capacities - such as generosity, ethical discipline, patience, faith, and wisdom - that can grow into awakening.
Vulture Peak Assembly	The gathering of Buddhas, bodhisattvas, and disciples associated with Śākyamuni's teachings at Vulture Peak, especially the *Lotus Sūtra*.
Warmth, Summit, Acceptance, and Supreme Attribute	Four preparatory stages immediately before direct liberating insight in an early scholastic path system. They describe increasing stability and clarity, not physical heat or social rank.
Water Repentance	The three-scroll repentance liturgy attributed to Master Wuda. "Water" recalls the spring that cleansed his affliction and symbolizes the Dharma washing away hatred and karmic obstruction.
Wheel of suffering; ocean or sea of suffering	Images for saṃsāra: repeated birth and death is pictured as a turning wheel or a dangerous ocean that is hard to cross.
Wheel-Turning Monarch	The ideal universal ruler of ancient Indian Buddhist cosmology, said to rule ethically and possess extraordinary signs and treasures. Even this exalted rebirth remains impermanent.
Wisdom of skilful means	Insight that knows not only the truth but also how to present and apply it compassionately for different beings.
Wish-fulfilling powers; mastery of mind and phenomena	Idealised abilities of advanced bodhisattvas to act freely and effectively for beings. They express spiritual freedom, not ordinary wish fulfilment for personal gain.
Yojana	An ancient Indian unit of long distance. Estimates vary; it is often approximated at roughly 6-16 kilometres. In the hell descriptions the huge measurements chiefly signal vast scale.
Yuan Yang and Yao Cuo; the human-faced tumour	Figures in the origin legend. Wuda is said to have been Yuan Yang in a past life, while the tumour embodies Yao Cuo's unresolved grievance after his execution; the story teaches that harm and resentment can persist until acknowledged and cleansed.

Passages and terms that remain unclear

The Fo Guang Shan/Hsi Lai terminology pass resolved many compressed lists, but a few phrases remain edition-specific or genuinely ambiguous:

- "Three Vows" is not enumerated. Several traditional triads have that name, and the surrounding verse does not identify which one is intended.
- "Nine Conditions" may refer to the nine supports for the arising of consciousness, but commentaries on this exact repentance passage do not agree. The glossary therefore explains its practical sense without presenting one disputed list as certain.
- "Eight Defilements," "nine obscurities covering the land," and the "Three Vows" remain broader than a single confidently identifiable list in this edition.
- "When the two practices are perfectly illuminated" does not name the pair. The source behind "our third practice, our third cleansing" is 三熏三沐 (*sān xūn sān mù*), an idiom of repeated perfuming and bathing that expresses reverent preparation. It is not a technical third practice or merely a reference to Scroll Three.
- "Its essence does not exceed even a square inch of space" in the imperial preface is syntactically unclear. It may point to the mind or heart as the compact locus of moral transformation, but the English sentence does not establish that securely.
- "We gave rise to [self-]nature without knowing" and "we were deluded to the one nature" are awkward translations. They appear to concern ignorance of the true nature of mind or reality, but their precise contrast is unclear.
- "Truth and worldliness lead away from each other" is understandable as a contrast between liberation and worldly attachment, but the sentence's exact logical connection to the Wuda story is unclear.
- Several apparent editorial errors should be corrected or confirmed before public use: "no part of it remains cleansed" appears to require "no part remains **uncleansed**"; "contemplation of **of** impurities" repeats "of"; "Dhama Body" appears to mean "Dharma Body"; "specs of dust" appears to mean "specks of dust"; "responsiblies" appears to mean "responsibilities"; and "Śākyamuṇi" is inconsistent with the edition's usual spelling "Śākyamuni."

- “The Honored One practiced kindness and reverently record this” is grammatically incomplete, and its intended subject and action are unclear.
- The transliterated mantra and dhāraṇī syllables are not ordinary English sentences. In accordance with the English-only scope, this glossary explains their headings and ritual functions but does not translate the syllables.

Sources used for the terminology pass

- Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple, *Samādhi Water Repentance*, Scrolls One, Two, and Three: https://www.hsilai.org/tc/events/eBooks/
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The glossary remains a reading aid rather than an authorized liturgical commentary. A temple teacher can still supply the intended source note for the few edition-specific phrases listed above.

Pronunciation

A companion to the glossary

This guide aims for a confident, recognisable first reading. It is not a substitute for listening to a temple officiant or trained language speaker.

Use **Buddhas and bodhisattvas in the three scrolls** when you need to know who a name identifies. Use this section when you know the figure and need a practical first pronunciation. Capital letters mark emphasis, not extra volume.

Quick Sanskrit key

Printed form	Approximate sound
ā	“ah”, held a little longer
ī	“ee”
ū	“oo”
ś, ṣ	“sh” for an easy first reading
c	“ch”
j	“j” as in “jam”
ñ	“ny” as in “canyon”
kṣ	roughly “ksh”
ṃ, ṁ	a nasal sound coloured by the next consonant
bh, dh, gh	a consonant followed by a light breath; plain “b”, “d” or “g” is acceptable for a beginner

Capital letters below show the strongest syllable. Hyphens mark comfortable reading units rather than exact linguistic syllables.

Names used often

Name	Easy English pronunciation
Śākyamuni	*SHAH-kyah-MOO-nee*
Vairocana	*vie-ROH-chah-nah*
Amitābha	*ah-mee-TAH-bhah*
Amitāyus	*ah-mee-TAH-yoos*
Maitreya	*my-TRAY-yah*
Bhaiṣajyaguru	*bye-SHAJ-yah-GOO-roo*
Dīpaṃkara	*dee-PUNG-kah-rah*
Avalokiteśvara	*ah-vah-loh-kee-TAYSH-vah-rah*
Guanyin	*gwahn-yin*
Mañjuśrī	*mun-joo-SHREE*
Samantabhadra	*sah-MUN-tah-BHAD-rah*
Mahāsthāmaprāpta	*mah-HAH-stah-mah-PRAHP-tah*
Kṣitigarbha	*kshih-tee-GAHR-bhah*
Prabhūtaratna	*prah-BOO-tah-RUT-nah*
Mahāvyūha	*mah-HAH-VYOO-hah*
Dharmākara	*dhar-MAA-kah-rah*
Tuṣita	*TOO-shih-tah*
Budai	*boo-dye*

Same figure, another name

Name you may encounter	Name used in these profiles	Reading note
Guanyin	Avalokiteśvara	The familiar Chinese name of the bodhisattva of compassion.
Amituofo	Amitābha Buddha	A Mandarin name-recitation form, approximately *ah-mee-twoh-foh*.
Yaoshi Fo	Medicine Master Buddha	Chinese for the Medicine Buddha.
Dizang	Kṣitigarbha	The Chinese name meaning “Earth Treasury”.
Wenshu	Mañjuśrī	The Chinese name of the bodhisattva of wisdom.
Puxian	Samantabhadra	The Chinese name of the bodhisattva of great practice and vows.
Dashizhi	Mahāsthāmaprāpta	The Chinese name of Amitābha's attendant associated with great strength.
Mile	Maitreya	The Chinese name of the future Buddha.

These spellings help with recognition. Mandarin tones and local liturgical pronunciation should be learnt by listening. Also distinguish **Kāśyapa Buddha**, the Buddha before Śākyamuni in the Seven Ancient Buddhas, from **Mahākāśyapa**, Śākyamuni's disciple.

Important Buddhist terms

Term	Easy English pronunciation
Buddha	*BOOD-uh*
bodhisattva	*boh-dee-SUT-vuh*
mahāsattva	*muh-HAH-SUT-vuh*
Dharma	*DAR-muh*
Sangha	*SUNG-huh*
Tathāgata	*tuh-THAH-guh-tuh*
Mahāyāna	*muh-hah-YAH-nuh*
samādhi	*suh-MAH-dee*
saṃsāra	*sum-SAH-ruh*
nirvāṇa	*neer-VAH-nuh*
karma	*KAR-muh*
sūtra	*SOO-truh*
dhāraṇī	*DHAH-ruh-nee*
pāramitā	*pah-ruh-mee-TAH*
prajñā	*PRUJ-nyah*
Sukhāvatī	*soo-KHAH-vah-tee*
Śāriputra	*SHAH-ree-POO-truh*
Uḍumbara	*oo-DOOM-bah-rah*
dhyāna	*DYAH-nuh*
stūpa	*STOO-puh*

Chanting the non-English lines

The English headings translate the **names and purposes** of the chants. The Latin-letter lines beneath them preserve Sanskrit or Sanskrit-derived sounds. They are transliterations, not badly translated English.

The cues below pronounce the source's Latin-letter form. Fo Guang Shan communal chanting follows its Chinese liturgical transmission, so the pinyin line and the officiant take priority when their sound differs from this cue.

Small form	Easy reading cue	Meaning or function
namaḥ / namo	*NAH-mah / NAH-moh*	Homage, honour or taking refuge.
oṃ	*ohm*	A sacred opening syllable.
hūṃ	*hoom*, ending nasally with the lips together	A forceful mantra syllable used to gather or seal intention.
svāhā	*SWAA-hah*	A traditional ending marking offering, fulfilment or completion.
hoḥ	*hoh*, ending with a soft breath	A concluding ritual syllable.

Seven Buddhas Offence-Extinguishing Mantra

Appears in: all three scrolls.

Source form: *ripa ripate kuha kuhate tranite nigalate*
vimarite mahāgate jāmlamcamte svāhā
Easy cue: *REE-pah REE-pah-tay, KOO-hah KOO-hah-tay, TRAH-nee-tay, NEE-gah-lah-tay; VEE-mah-ree-tay, mah-HAA-gah-tay, JAHM-lahm-CHAHM-tay, SWAA-hah.*

The complete wording is not secure Classical Sanskrit and should not be forced into a word-by-word translation. Its title gives the dependable sense: purification of offences and karmic obstructions through the witness and blessing of the Seven Buddhas. *Mahā* means "great"; *gate* is related to going or having gone; *svāhā* closes the formula.

Heart Sūtra mantra

Appears in: the memorial rites of Scrolls One and Three.

Source form: *gate gate pāragate pārasaṃgate bodhi svāhā*
Easy cue: *GAH-tay GAH-tay PAA-rah-gah-tay PAA-rah-sung-gah-tay BOH-dhee SWAA-hah.*

A common interpretive sense is "gone, gone, gone beyond, gone completely beyond, awakening, svāhā". It points beyond fear and clinging, not to physical travel.

Rebirth in the Pure Land Dhāraṇī

Appears in: the memorial rites of Scrolls One and Three.

Source form: *Namo'mitābhāya tathāgatāya tadyathā*
[oṃ] amṛtod bhave amṛta-siddhaṃ bhave
amṛta-vikrānte amṛta-vikrānta
gāmini gagana kīrta kāre svāhā
Easy cue: *NAH-moh ah-mee-TAA-bhaa-yah tah-THAA-gah-taa-yah tud-yuh-THAA; ohm uh-MRIH-tohd BHAH-vay, uh-MRIH-tah SID-dhum BHAH-vay; uh-MRIH-tah vee-KRAAN-tay, uh-MRIH-tah vee-KRAAN-tah; GAA-mee-nee GAH-gah-nah KEER-tah KAA-ray SWAA-hah.*

The opening means "Homage to Amitābha Tathāgata; thus". *Amṛta* is "deathless" or "nectar", and *siddhaṃ* concerns accomplishment. The overall function is purification and aspiration for rebirth in Amitābha's Pure Land. The later transmitted wording is not translated more narrowly than the evidence permits.

Transformation of Food Dhāraṇī

Appears in: the Noon Offering and memorial rites of Scroll One, and the memorial rite of Scroll Three.

Source form: *Namaḥ sarva-tathāgatāvalokite; oṃ sambhara sambhara hūṃ*
Easy cue: *NAH-mah SAR-vah tah-THAA-gah-TAA-vah-loh-kee-tay; ohm SUM-bha-rah SUM-bha-rah hoom.*

The opening honours all Tathāgatas who behold. The formula expresses gathering, supplying or making the offering abundant so that a limited portion can be offered to innumerable beings.

Sweet Dew Dhāraṇī

Appears in: the Noon Offering and memorial rites of Scroll One, and the memorial rite of Scroll Three.

Source form: *Namaḥ surūpāya tathāgatāya tadyathā; oṃ suru suru pra suru pra suru svāhā*
Easy cue: *NAH-mah soo-ROO-paa-yah tah-THAA-gah-taa-yah tud-yuh-THAA; ohm SOO-roo SOO-roo prah SOO-roo prah SOO-roo SWAA-hah.*

The opening honours the Beautiful-Form Tathāgata. The repeated *suru* sounds are retained without inventing a separate meaning. "Sweet dew" is deathless nectar, an image of cooling nourishment, Dharma relief and liberation.

Universal Offering Dhāraṇī

Appears in: the Noon Offering and memorial rites of Scroll One, and the memorial rite of Scroll Three.

> **Source form:** *Oṃ gagana sambhava vajra hoḥ*
> **Easy cue:** *ohm GAH-gah-nah SUM-bha-vah VAJ-rah hoh.*

The recognisable words suggest “arisen from space” and *vajra*, the diamond or thunderbolt symbol of indestructible awakened power. Its ritual purpose is to extend the offering throughout the whole Dharma realm.

Celestial Kitchen Praise formula

Appears in: the Noon Offering of Scroll One.

> **Source form:** *Oṃ suru-sarva tathāgata tadyathā suru svāhā*
> **Easy cue:** *ohm SOO-roo SAR-vah tah-THAA-gah-tah tud-yuh-THAA SOO-roo SWAA-hah.*

Sarva tathāgata means “all Tathāgatas” and *tadyathā* means “thus”. The *suru* sounds are preserved. The formula consecrates and universally directs the food offering.

A small Vietnamese name bridge

The source PDF is not Vietnamese. This table is included only because an English reader may hear these names at a Vietnamese Mahāyāna temple.

Vietnamese tones matter, and the cues below are deliberately rough. Northern and Southern pronunciation differ, especially where a written **d** may sound closer to English “z” in the north and “y” in the south.

English or Sanskrit name	Vietnamese name	Rough cue for recognition
Śākyamuni Buddha	**Phật Thích Ca Mâu Ni**	*fuht tick kah mow nee*
Amitābha Buddha	**Phật A Di Đà**	*fuht ah zee-dah* or southern *ah yee-dah*
Avalokiteśvara	**Quán Thế Âm**	*kwahn tay uhm*
Kṣitigarbha	**Địa Tạng**	*zee-uh tahng* or southern *yee-uh tahng*
Maitreya	**Di Lặc**	*zee luck* or southern *yee luck*
Mañjuśrī	**Văn Thù**	*vun too*
Samantabhadra	**Phổ Hiền**	*faw hee-en*
Medicine Buddha	**Phật Dược Sư**	*fuht zuhrk suh* or southern *yuhrk suh*

Nam Mô A Di Đà Phật

Rough cue: *nahm moh ah zee-dah fuht*, with Southern **Di** often nearer *yee*. *Phật* ends in a short, unreleased “t”.

Meaning: “Homage to Amitābha Buddha” or “I take refuge in Amitābha Buddha”. It is a Vietnamese form of Buddha-name recitation. Listen and follow the local temple's rhythm and tones rather than forcing the English cue.

The related Mandarin form, **Namo Amituofo** (*nah-moh ah-mee-twoh-foh*), also recollects Amitābha and expresses aspiration towards **Sukhāvatī**, his Western Pure Land. This is a Buddha-field with exceptionally supportive conditions for continued practice without retrogression, rather than another level of the six realms or an eternal heaven.

Pure Land liturgy pictures the nine grades of lotus blossoms as one's parents. In this imagery, a person is reborn through transformation from a lotus rather than gestated in a womb. The opening blossom represents seeing Amitābha, hearing the Dharma and awakening to non-arising.

> **A popular devotional image:** Some later Pure Land teaching pictures faith, vows, name-recitation and practice nourishing a lotus in Sukhāvatī, sometimes bearing the practitioner's name. It expresses confidence in future lotus birth. This detail appears neither in the Water Repentance nor in the shorter *Amitābha Sūtra*.

References

Sources and editorial limits

The original reference set was checked on 24 August 2026. Sources added for the expanded figure profiles and reading aids were checked on 27 September 2026. This does not claim that every earlier external link was rechecked on the later date. The guide paraphrases its copyrighted source and uses short labels only where necessary for explanation.

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- Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy. Japanese Pure Land Philosophy. Used cautiously for the broader doctrinal distinction between Pure Land aspiration and ordinary saṃsāric heaven. The companion does not treat the Chinese liturgy as a Japanese sectarian text.

Figure relationships and recognition

These museum and institutional records support the profile's visual cues and relationship notes. They do not imply that every regional image uses the same attributes.

- National Museum of Asian Art. *The Buddha Shakyamuni with the Bodhisattvas Samantabhadra and Manjushri*. Śākyamuni's East Asian grouping with wisdom and practice.
- The Metropolitan Museum of Art. *Amitabha triad* and stele with Avalokiteśvara and Mahāsthāmaprāpta. The Western Pure Land triad and crown emblems.
- The Metropolitan Museum of Art. Buddha Vairocana. The wisdom-fist gesture in one East Asian esoteric form.
- The Metropolitan Museum of Art. Buddha of Medicine mural. Medicine Master with Sunlight and Moonlight bodhisattvas and twelve guardians.
- The Metropolitan Museum of Art. Mañjuśrī and Kṣitigarbha. The wisdom sword and text; the monastic robe, staff and jewel.
- The Metropolitan Museum of Art. Gandharan Maitreya and Budai. Maitreya in Tuṣita and the later East Asian identification of the laughing monk Budai with Maitreya.

- Norton Simon Museum. Dīpamkara Buddha; and The Metropolitan Museum of Art, Dīpamkara and Sumedha. Museum summaries of the traditional prediction story and variations in the bodhisattva's name.

Artwork records

Each image caption in FIGURES.md gives its direct museum or Wikimedia source and licence. Key collection records include:

- The Metropolitan Museum of Art: Avalokiteśvara, Samantabhadra, Mahāsthāmaprāpta and Kṣitigarbha.
- Wikimedia Commons: Śākyamuni, Vairocana, Amitābha, Dīpamkara, Maitreya, Medicine Master Buddha, Prabhūtaratna and Śākyamuni and the Seven Buddhas.

Editorial limits

- Sanskrit names and terms are normalised only where the identification is secure. The source spelling remains the reference for chanting.
- English pronunciation cues are approximations, not International Phonetic Alphabet transcriptions. In communal chanting, the officiant and the source's pinyin rhythm take priority.
- Mantra words are translated only where the Sanskrit sense is reasonably secure. Transmitted syllables with uncertain grammar are explained by ritual function rather than assigned an invented literal meaning.
- Lotus birth is distinguished from the later devotional image of a name-bearing lotus. The former is widely attested in Pure Land sources; the latter is presented as a teaching image, not as a sentence from the source liturgy.
- Vietnamese names are a recognition aid only. Tone and regional pronunciation should be learned from a Vietnamese speaker or temple.
- Literal and psychological interpretations of cosmological realms are both identified as recognised approaches. The guide does not claim that all Buddhist traditions interpret them in the same way.
- The traditional Wuda narrative is explained respectfully and distinguished from historical verification.

May the benefit of this work support understanding, compassionate reform and the awakening of all beings.